for a breakaway. They looked like they were enjoying themselves. I can't say we did. The best that could be said was that we stuck at it. We won 2–0 and got our three points.

So it came down to Greece at Old Trafford. Beating Albania meant we went into our last qualifying game level on points at the top of the group with Germany but with a better goal difference. Perhaps it would have been easier—on everybody's nerves, at least—if we could have gone straight on to that game the following weekend. We'd have been tired but we were so disappointed by how we played against Albania that we'd have had something to react to and something to prove. If we'd played Greece that Saturday I think, like a club side, we'd have kicked on and beaten them. Instead we had to wait a month. A month during which everybody needed to concentrate on winning games back with their clubs. A month for doubts to set in ahead of the match that might decide England's international summer. Those weeks dragged and, once the squad got together again, so did the days building up to the game itself.

We met up on the Sunday and stayed at the Marriott Hotel in the suburbs of Manchester. It seemed like we were rattling around there together for ages, just wanting to get on with Saturday afternoon and what we had to do. Inside the hotel, just like outside it, everybody was talking about the importance of the game and about what automatic qualification for the World Cup would mean. Did we have to win? Would a draw be enough? What about goal difference? You can get suffocated with all that. What was important was that beating Greece would mean it didn't matter what the Germans did. That was what we had to keep in focus. It didn't help that the media and England supporters seemed to think the hard work was over and that we were on to a sure bet. Saturday came and there was far more tension about than there should have been.

I was on edge as much as everybody else, although I had more to help me get through it than some of the other England players. First, the game was at Old Trafford. I'd come on as a substitute the last time we'd had an international there, against South Africa, back in 1997. Now, 6 October 2001, and I was a United player leading out the England team as captain. Who wouldn't be looking forward to a moment like that? Second, we were playing in an all-white strip. During the week, the England equipment man came to find out if I thought he should ask Sven if we could. United's all-white change strip, the England version or even Real Madrid's colors, come to that: I've always loved that uniform. And the England manager agreed that we'd wear it against Greece. I had that and my home ground to look forward to. What I